THE VIRAL FEVER / LCX

TVF Lead Engine

How to use it, screen by screen

The Viral Fever / LCX

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What this tool is

The Lead Engine finds companies and people worth emailing, gathers the evidence for why they are worth emailing, scores them, writes a first email to each one, and holds every email until a person reads it and says yes.

It does not send anything on its own. That is the whole design.

There are two halves:

The engine runs on its own. It searches YouTube, Apple Podcasts, Wikidata and news feeds, reads public pages, works out who is behind a show or a studio, scores each one against a written rubric, and writes a draft email built from that company's own numbers.

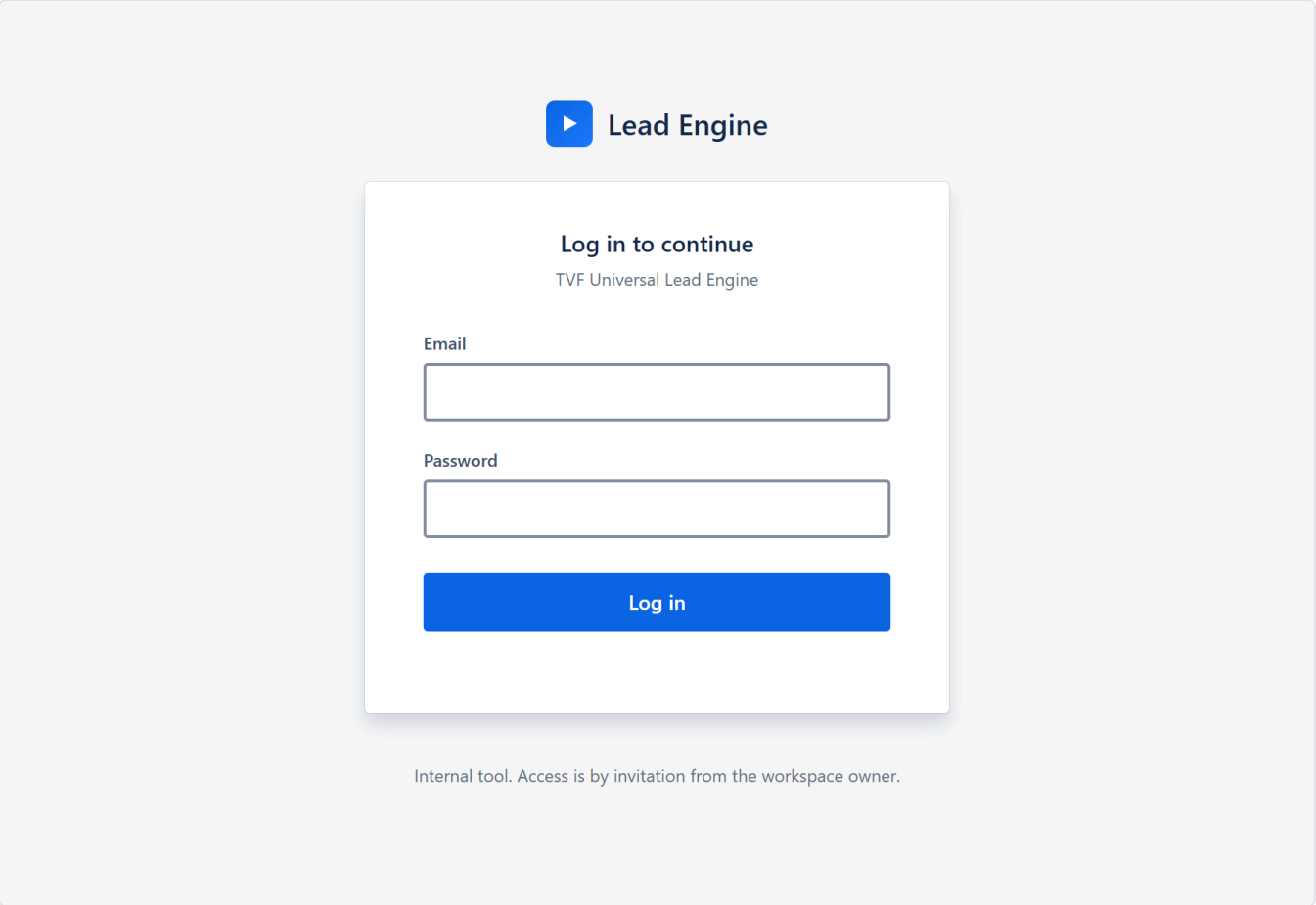
You do the part a machine should not do. You look at what it found, decide yes or no, read the emails it wrote, and approve the ones you stand behind.

A normal day is twenty minutes: open the board, work through the new leads, shortlist the good ones, then read and approve the emails that were drafted overnight.

> The screenshots in this manual come from the real app, loaded with a snapshot of the live pool. The email addresses in them end in `example.com` because a manual gets shared and a real prospect's address does not belong in a PDF.

Getting in

Open the site in any browser. You will be asked to log in.



The sign-in screen

The first time anyone ever opens it, the screen asks you to create the owner account instead: an email address and a password of at least ten characters. That account is created once and only once.

To give a colleague access, the owner runs this on their machine:

```
python tools/users.py add teammate@theviralfever.com
```

It asks for a password, twice, and never puts it in a command. `users.py list` shows who has access, `passwd` resets a forgotten password, and `remove` takes access away.

There is no "sign up" link and no password reset by email. That is deliberate. Everything in this tool sits behind that one login, including every screen, every number and every draft email.

The shape of the app

Down the left is the menu. Five places, and you will live in three of them.

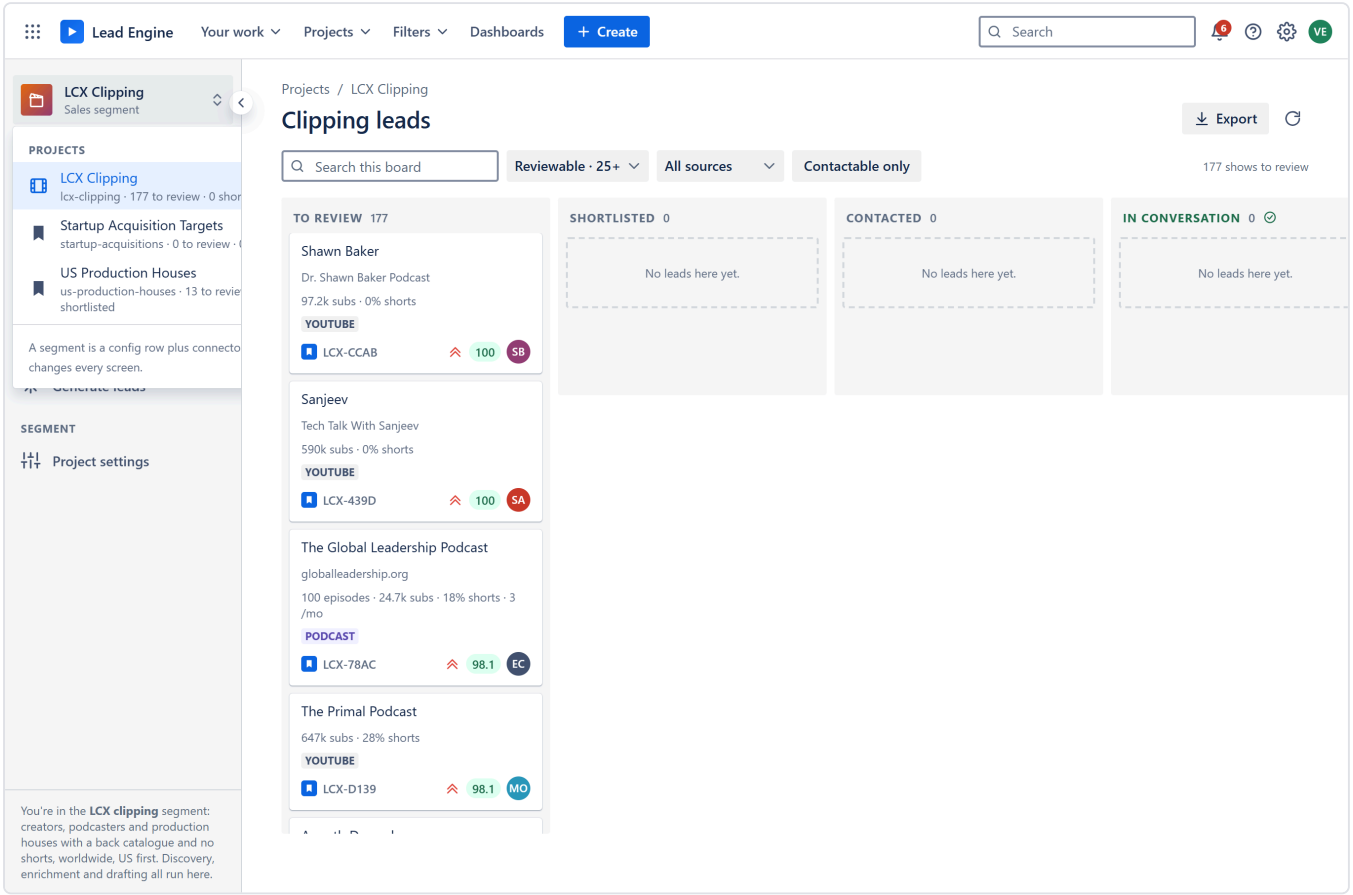
WHERE	WHAT IT IS FOR
Board	The pipeline at a glance. Cards move left to right as you decide on them.
Leads	The full list, with search and filters. Better than the board once you have hundreds.
Outreach	Every email. Drafts waiting for you, approved ones, sent ones, and replies.
Reports	Are we finding enough? Are we contacting enough? Is the scoring working?
Operations	Run the engine by hand, see what is scheduled, check the mailboxes.

Below those: **Generate leads** starts a harvest, and **Project settings** shows the rubric this project scores against.

Switching between projects

A **project** (the code calls it a segment) is one sales motion with its own leads, its own rubric, its own email templates and its own mailboxes. Nothing leaks between them.

Click the project name at the very top of the left sidebar to switch.



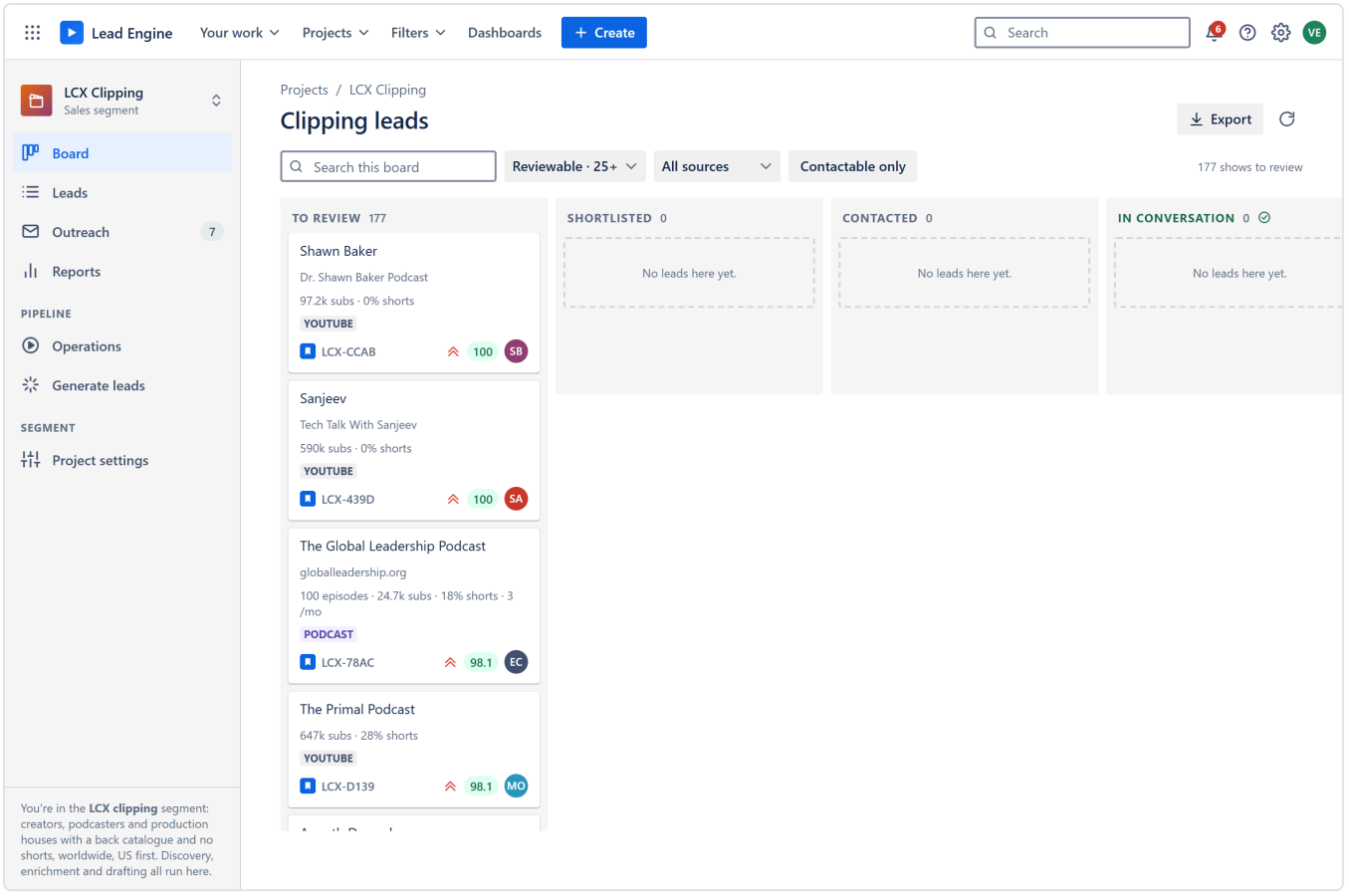
Click the project at the top of the sidebar to switch

Right now there are three:

- **LCX Clipping** — creators, podcasters and production houses with a deep back catalogue and almost no short-form. This is the active one.
- **US Production Houses** — TVF co-production targets.
- **Startup Acquisitions** — creator-tools and media-tech companies.

Whichever project you pick, every screen changes with it. The board, the leads, the emails, the reports. Check the sidebar if you are ever unsure which one you are looking at.

The board



The board: everything the engine found, by where it sits

Four columns, left to right. A lead only ever moves forward.

To review — the engine found it and scored it. Nobody has decided yet. This is your inbox.

Shortlisted — you said yes. The engine will write it an email.

Contacted — an email has been sent. The engine will not start a second thread with this company, ever.

In conversation — they replied and the reply was a real one. Your job now, not the tool's.

Above the columns are a search box and three filters: score, source, and **Contactable only**, which hides everything the engine has no address for.

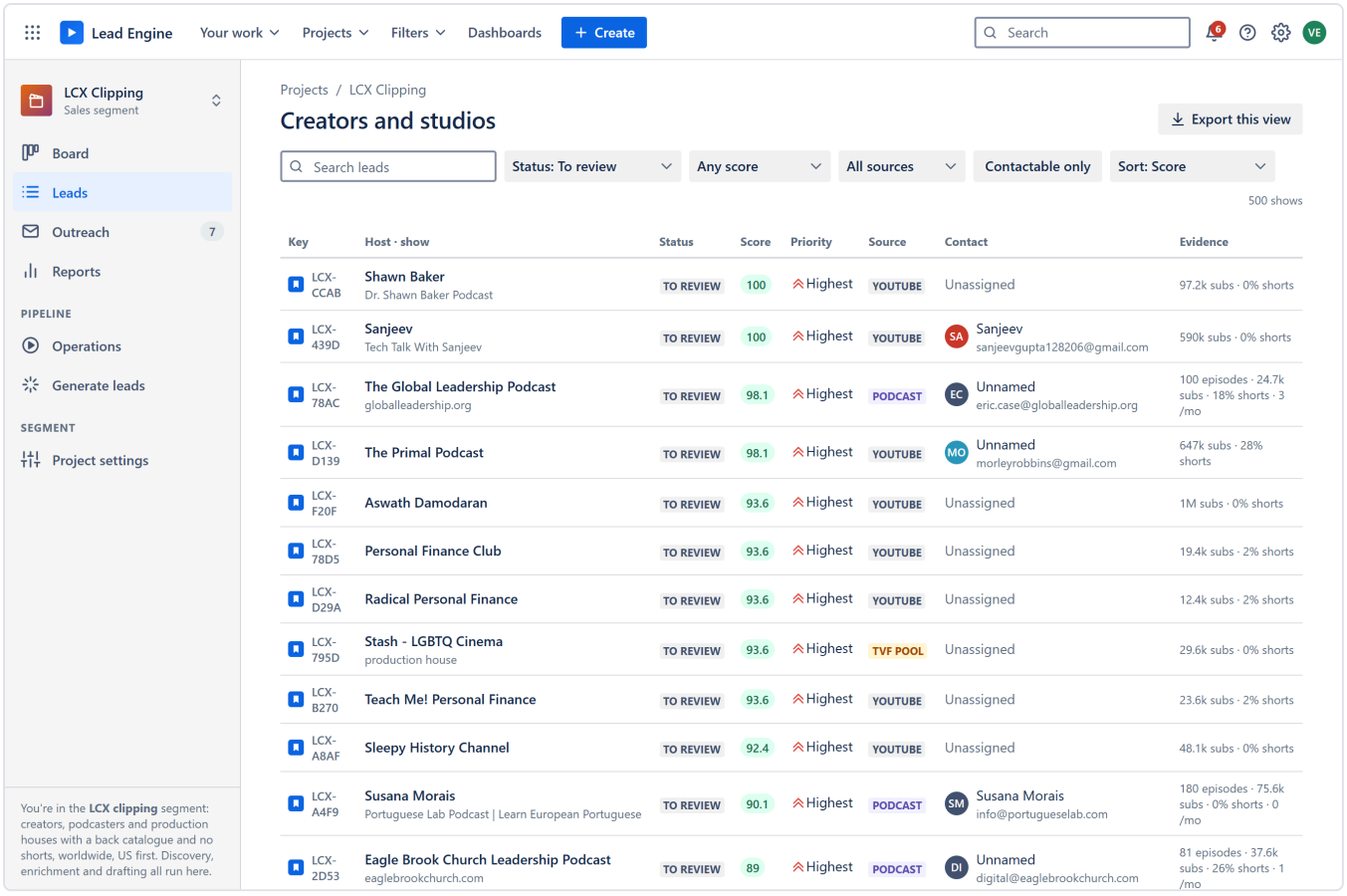
Reading a card

Each card shows the person first when the engine could work out who is behind the show, and the show or company underneath. Below that are the numbers that made it interesting: subscribers, how much short-form it publishes, how many episodes, how often.

On the bottom row: the lead's key (like `LCX-CCAB`, the name you can quote to a colleague), a priority arrow, and the fit score.

The score is out of 110 and is explained in full inside the lead. Anything at or above 25 is worth a look; 45 and up is the priority band.

The leads list



The same leads as a list, with filters

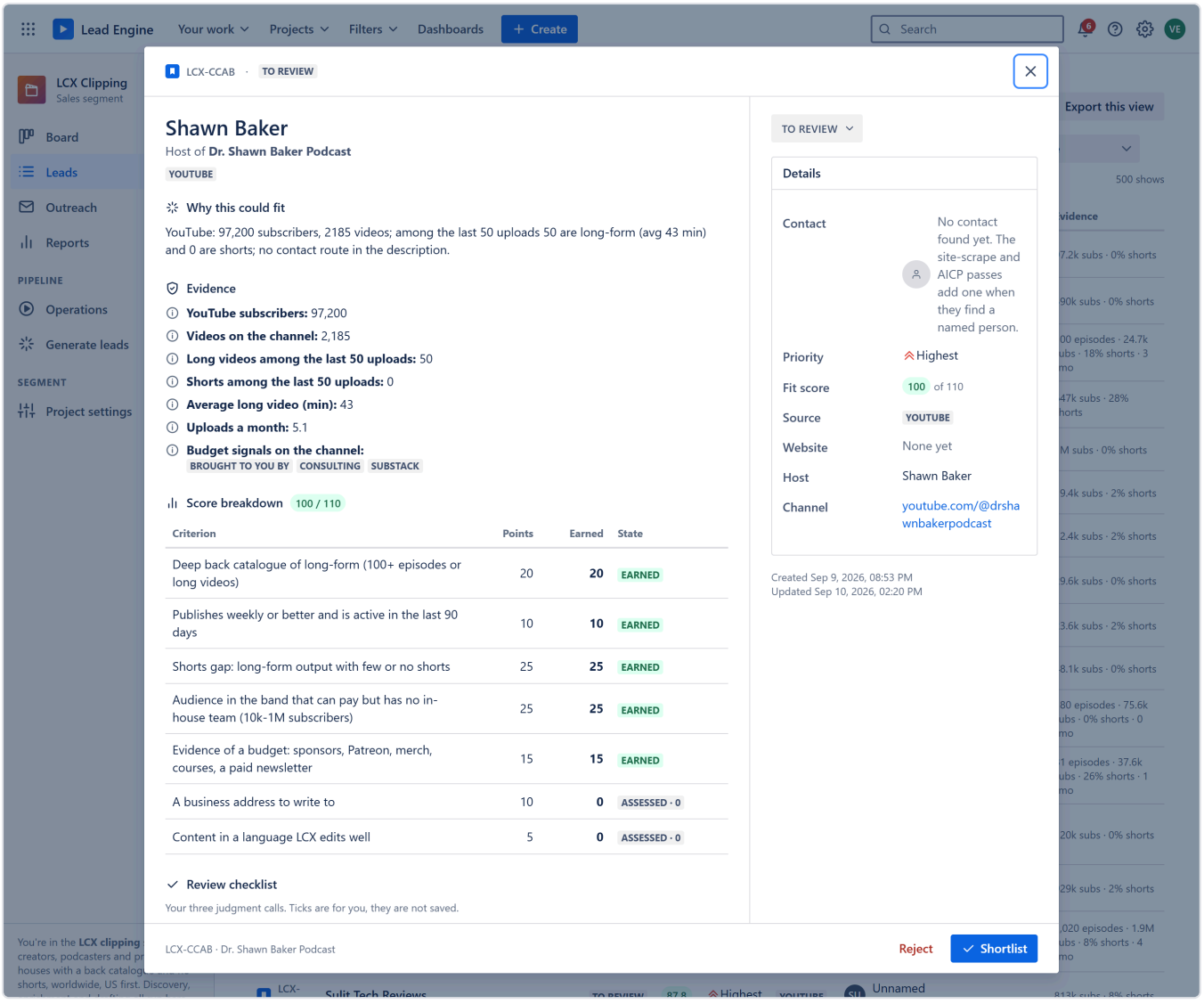
The board is nice for twenty leads. Past that, use this.

Search matches the show name, the host's name and the website. The filters along the top narrow by status, by score, by which connector found it, and by whether there is a contact. **Export this view** downloads exactly what you are looking at as a spreadsheet.

Click anywhere on a row to open it.

Deciding on a lead

This is the main job. Click any row or card.



Everything the engine knows, and the two buttons that matter

Read it top to bottom:

Why this could fit is one honest sentence built from their real numbers.

Evidence is the raw facts, each one a thing the engine actually observed: subscribers, videos, how many of the last 50 uploads were long-form, how many were shorts, the average length, how often they publish, and any sign they spend money (sponsors, Patreon, merch, a paid newsletter).

Score breakdown shows every criterion, what it is worth, and what this lead earned. Three states:

- **Earned** — the criterion was met.
- **Assessed · 0** — the engine looked and this lead did not meet it.
- **Not assessed** — the engine could not check. It counts as nothing, not as a failure.

Review checklist is three judgment calls the engine cannot make. The ticks are for your own thinking and are not saved anywhere.

On the right: the contact, the priority, the score, where it came from, the host, and a link to the channel. Open the channel and look at it before you decide. Thirty seconds there beats any rubric.

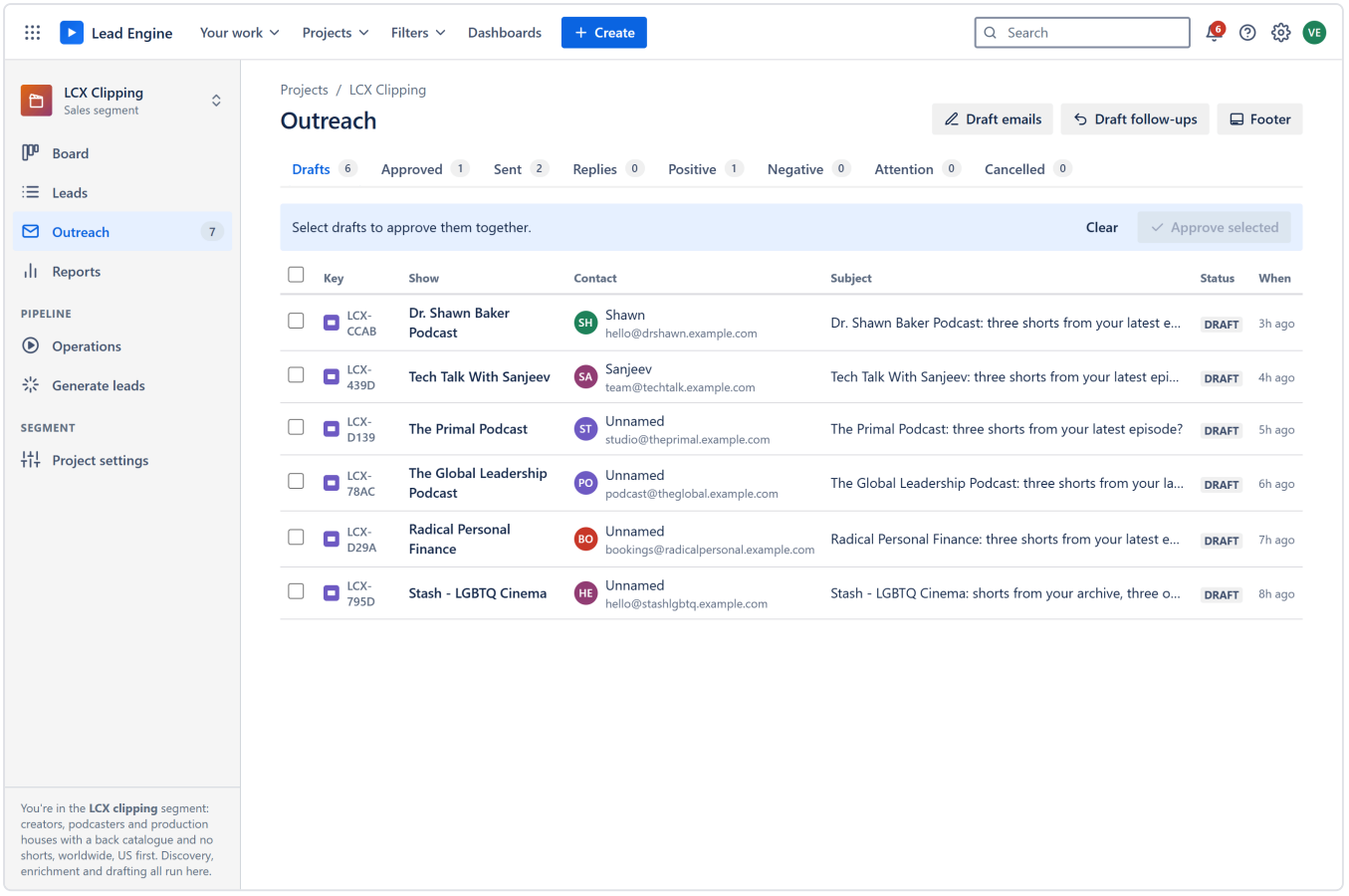
Then press one of two buttons at the bottom:

Shortlist — the engine will write this one an email.

Reject — it leaves the pipeline. A rejected lead is shielded permanently: no later harvest, re-import or reset will bring it back. If you reject something by mistake, reopen it from the Leads list with the status filter set to Rejected and use the status dropdown at the top right of the dialog.

Outreach

Every email lives here, in folders.



The Drafts folder: emails waiting to be read

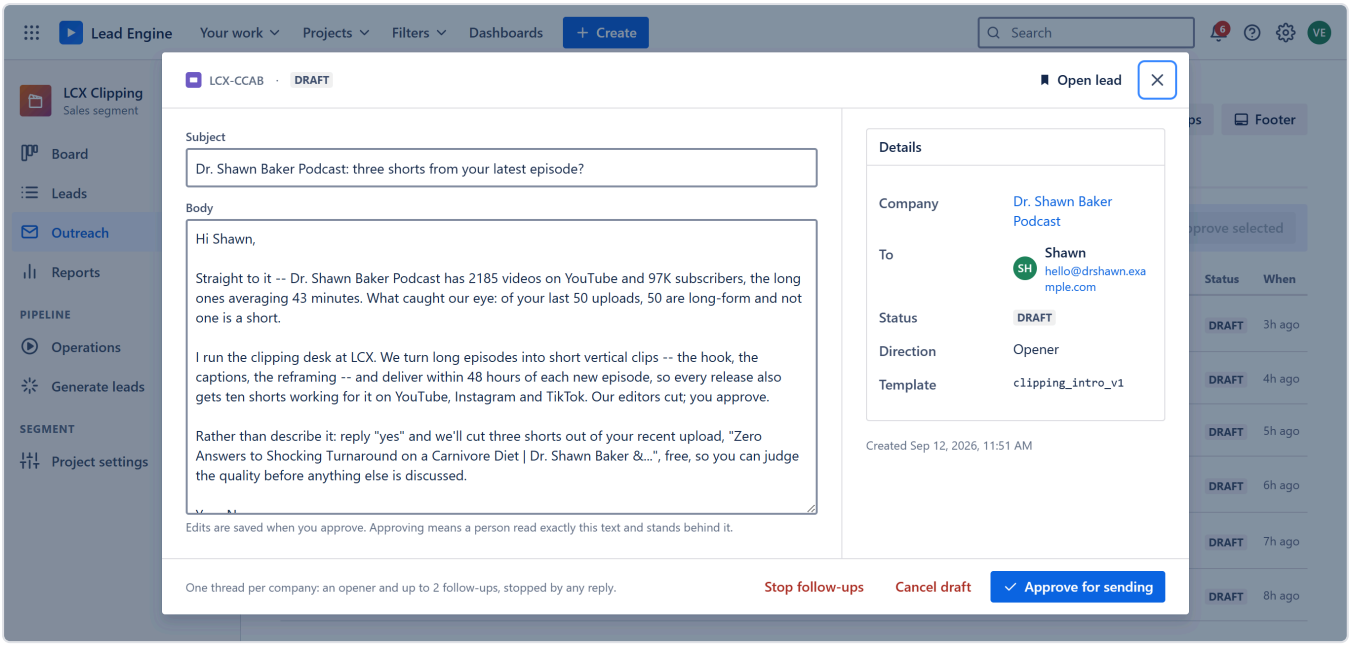
FOLDER	WHAT IS IN IT
Drafts	Written by the engine. Nothing has been sent. Waiting for you.
Approved	You said yes. Waiting for the next send run.
Sent	Gone.
Replies	Came back, not yet judged.
Positive / Negative	Replies you or the triage step have labelled.
Attention	Something went wrong with a send. Look at these.
Cancelled	Withdrawn before sending.

Two buttons at the top right:

Draft emails writes a first email for every shortlisted lead that does not have one yet. **Draft follow-ups** writes the follow-ups that have come due. Both only create drafts; neither sends anything.

Approving one email

Click any row in Drafts.



A draft, with the Approve button

The subject and the body are editable. Change anything you like: the whole point is that what you approve is what goes out, word for word.

Notice what is personal in it. The greeting is their first name, never the show's name. The opening sentence is their own numbers. The offer names their actual most recent episode. None of that was invented; all of it came from the evidence on the lead.

Approve for sending records your name against the email and moves it to Approved.

Cancel draft throws it away.

Stop follow-ups ends the whole thread with that company. No further follow-up will ever be drafted for them.

Approving does not send

This is worth saying plainly. Approving marks an email as ready. The actual send happens when someone runs the send command in a terminal:

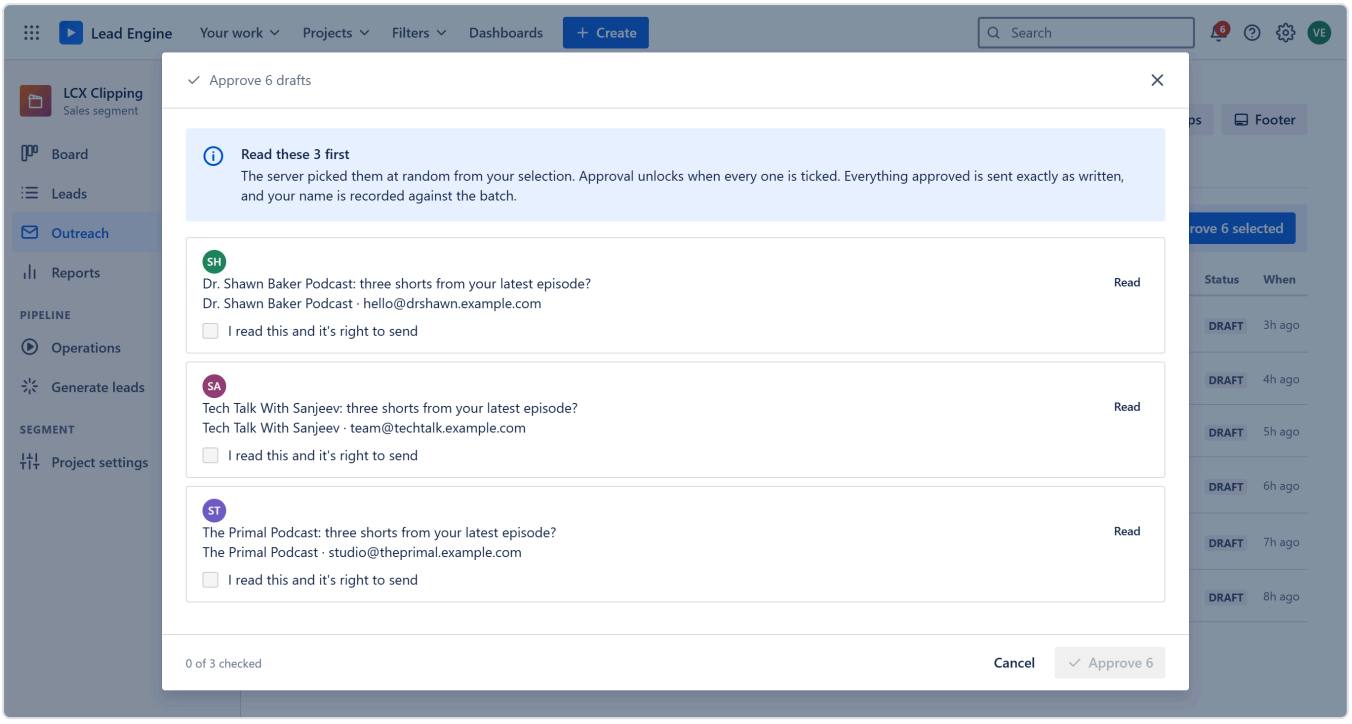
```
SEGMENT_SLUG=lcx-clipping python tools/outreach.py send
```

It sends only approved emails, never more than the daily cap, and refuses any address that failed verification. Nothing on any screen can send an email.

Approving many at once

Reading six hundred emails one at a time is not realistic, so the app has a second route that is still honest about what you read.

1. Tick the checkbox on each draft you want, or the one in the header to take the whole page.
2. A bar appears at the top. Press **Approve N selected**.
3. The server picks a random sample from your selection and shows you those.



You read a random sample the server picked; everything else follows

You have to read each one in the sample and tick it before the Approve button turns on. The sample is at least three, or one in ten, whichever is bigger, and you cannot choose which ones you get. Every email in the batch is checked first for unfilled placeholders, a missing sender, a bad address or a company that has moved on; anything that fails is left behind and named.

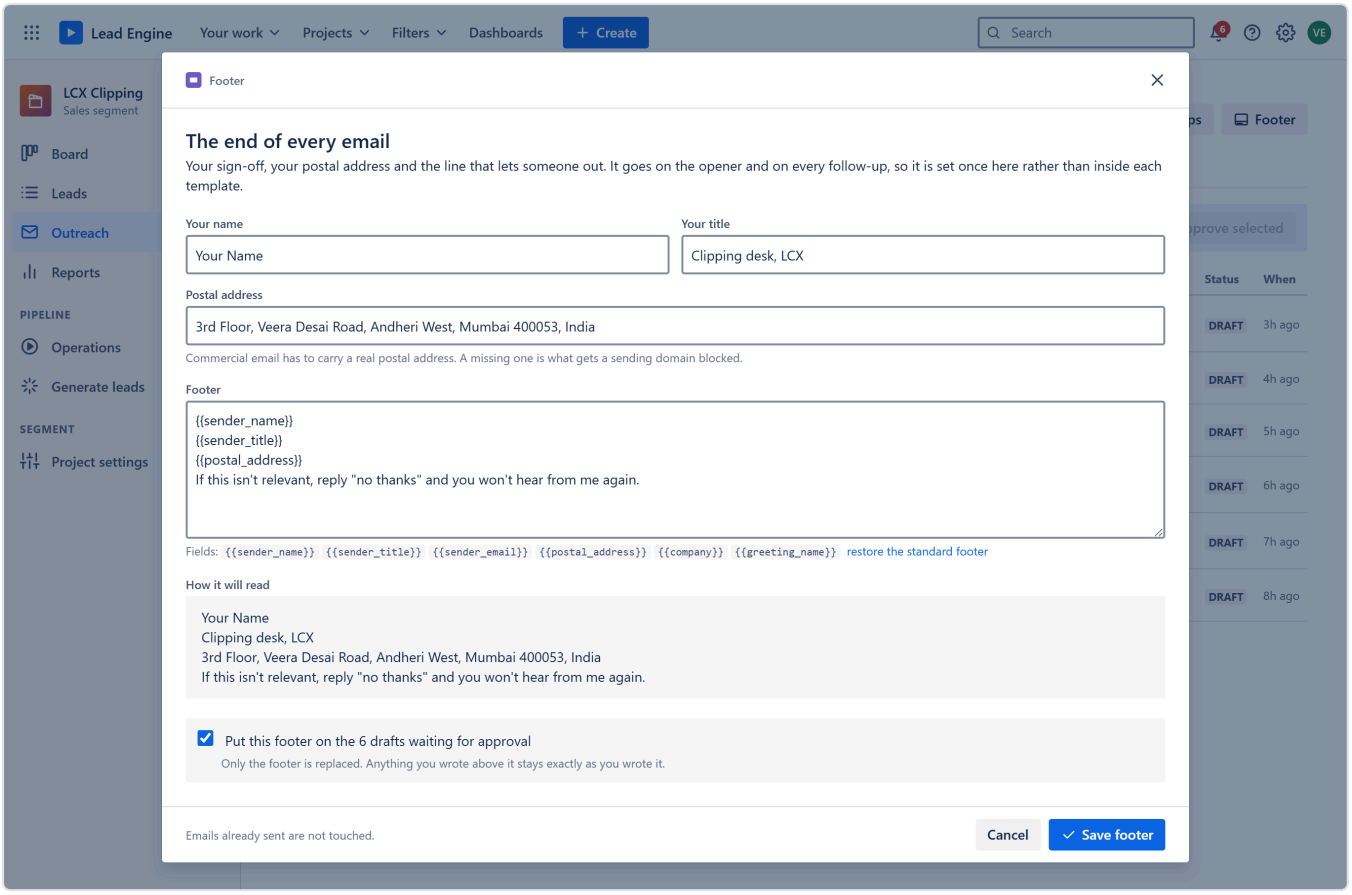
Afterwards, each email records your name, the batch it belonged to, and whether it was one of the ones you actually read.

Batch approval is on for LCX Clipping only. The TVF projects still require one approval per email.

The footer

The sign-off, the postal address and the line that lets someone out are the same on every email. They are one setting, not four lines buried in each template.

Press **Footer** at the top of the Outreach screen.



Your name, your address, and the block every email ends with

Fill in your name, your title and your postal address. The preview underneath shows exactly how the block will read.

Two things it will not let you do:

- **Save without a postal address.** Commercial email has to carry one, and a missing address is the fastest way to get a sending domain blocked.
- **Save without a way out.** Keep the line that tells the recipient how to stop hearing from you. It is the law, and it is the difference between a reply and a spam report.

When you save, it offers to put the new footer on the drafts already waiting for approval. Only the footer is replaced; anything you wrote by hand above it stays exactly as you wrote it. Emails already sent are never touched.

Follow-ups

For LCX Clipping, one company gets one thread: the opener, then up to two follow-ups in the same email thread.

- **Follow-up 1** four days after the opener.
- **Follow-up 2** seven days after that.
- Then the thread is closed for good.

Any reply stops it immediately. A genuine reply ends the thread; an out-of-office lets it resume. This is enforced in the database, not just in the app, so a follow-up cannot be sent to someone who has already written back even if something else goes wrong.

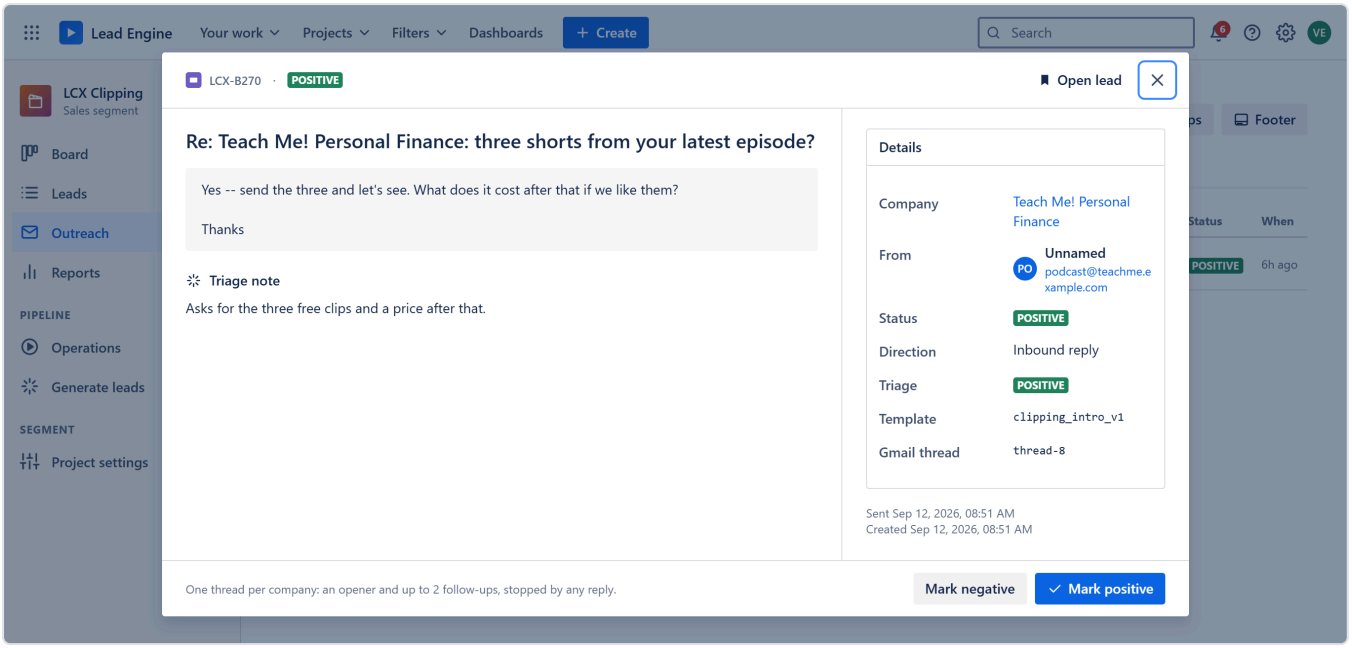
Follow-ups are drafts like any other email and need the same approval. Press **Draft follow-ups** to write the ones that are due, then read and approve them.

To stop a thread by hand, open any message in it and press **Stop follow-ups**.

The TVF projects do not use follow-ups at all. One email per company, full stop.

Replies

When someone writes back, their reply appears in **Replies**. Open it.



A reply, with the two buttons that close the loop

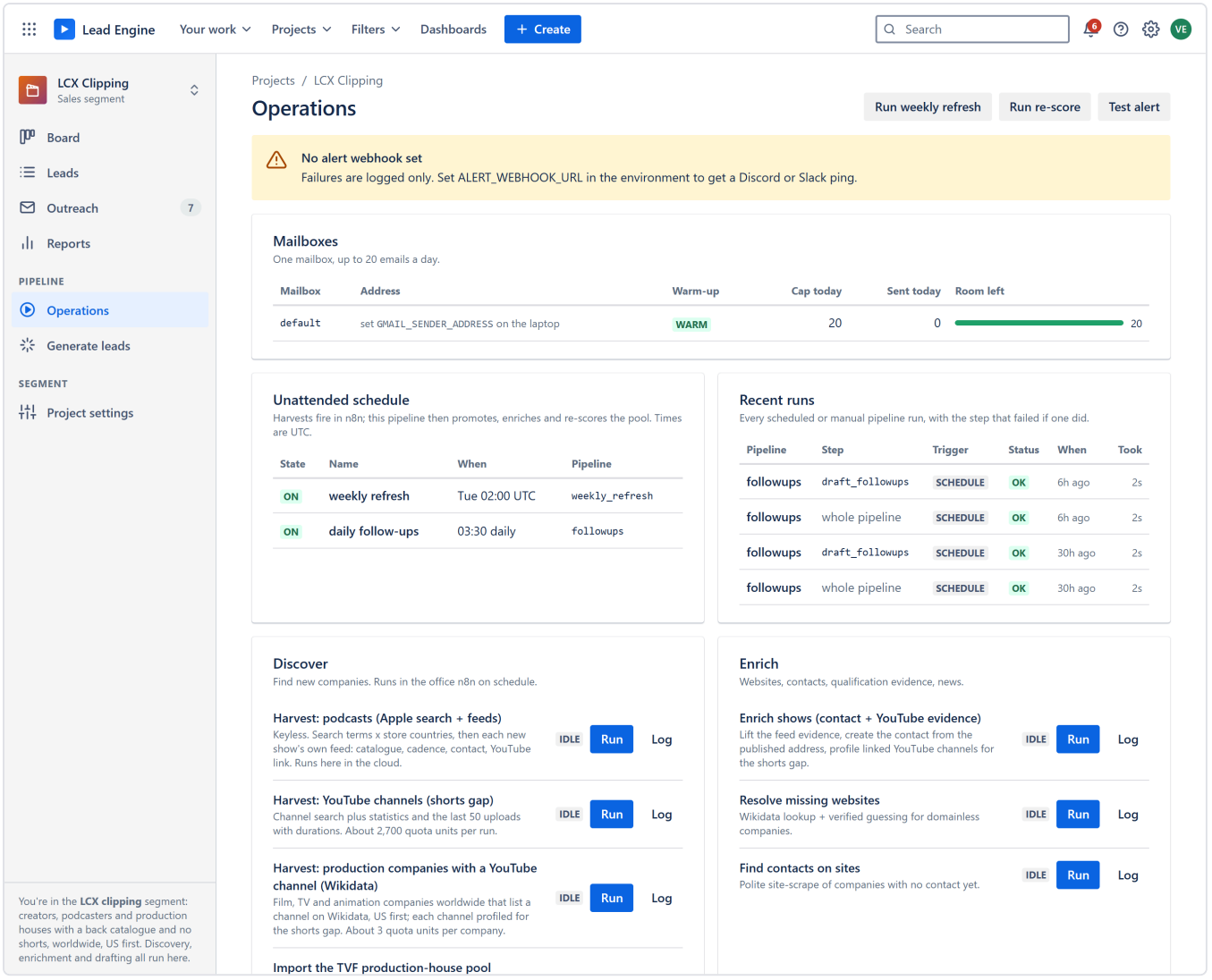
You mark it **Positive** or **Negative**.

Positive moves the company to **In conversation** on the board and hands it to you. Negative closes it out. Either way the follow-up thread stops.

If an Anthropic key is configured, a triage step reads new replies first and suggests a label with a one-line reason. It is a suggestion. Your click is what counts.

A bounce (a mailer-daemon reply) is handled without you: the address is marked invalid, the thread ends, and no mailbox writes to that address again.

Operations



Run the engine by hand, and see what it has been doing

Running a step

Each button runs one piece of the engine and streams its log to the screen. They come in four groups:

Discover goes out and finds new candidates: YouTube channels, Apple Podcasts shows, production companies from Wikidata, the TVF pool import.

Enrich fills in what is missing: the contact address, the channel behind a website, the evidence the scoring needs.

Process turns raw finds into scored leads: deduplicate, promote, score, apply the gates.

Outreach drafts the emails.

You do not normally need any of these. The schedule runs them for you. Use them when you want more leads today, or when you have changed something and want to see the effect now.

Only one job runs at a time. The log panel stays on screen afterwards so you can read what happened.

Mailboxes

The Mailboxes panel shows each sending address, how much it can send today, how much it has already sent, and how much room is left.

New mailboxes **warm up**: ten emails a day to start, five more every two days, up to forty. Three warm mailboxes give 120 a day, which is also the project ceiling. This is not caution for its own sake; a new address that sends eighty cold emails on day one gets filtered, and then none of them arrive.

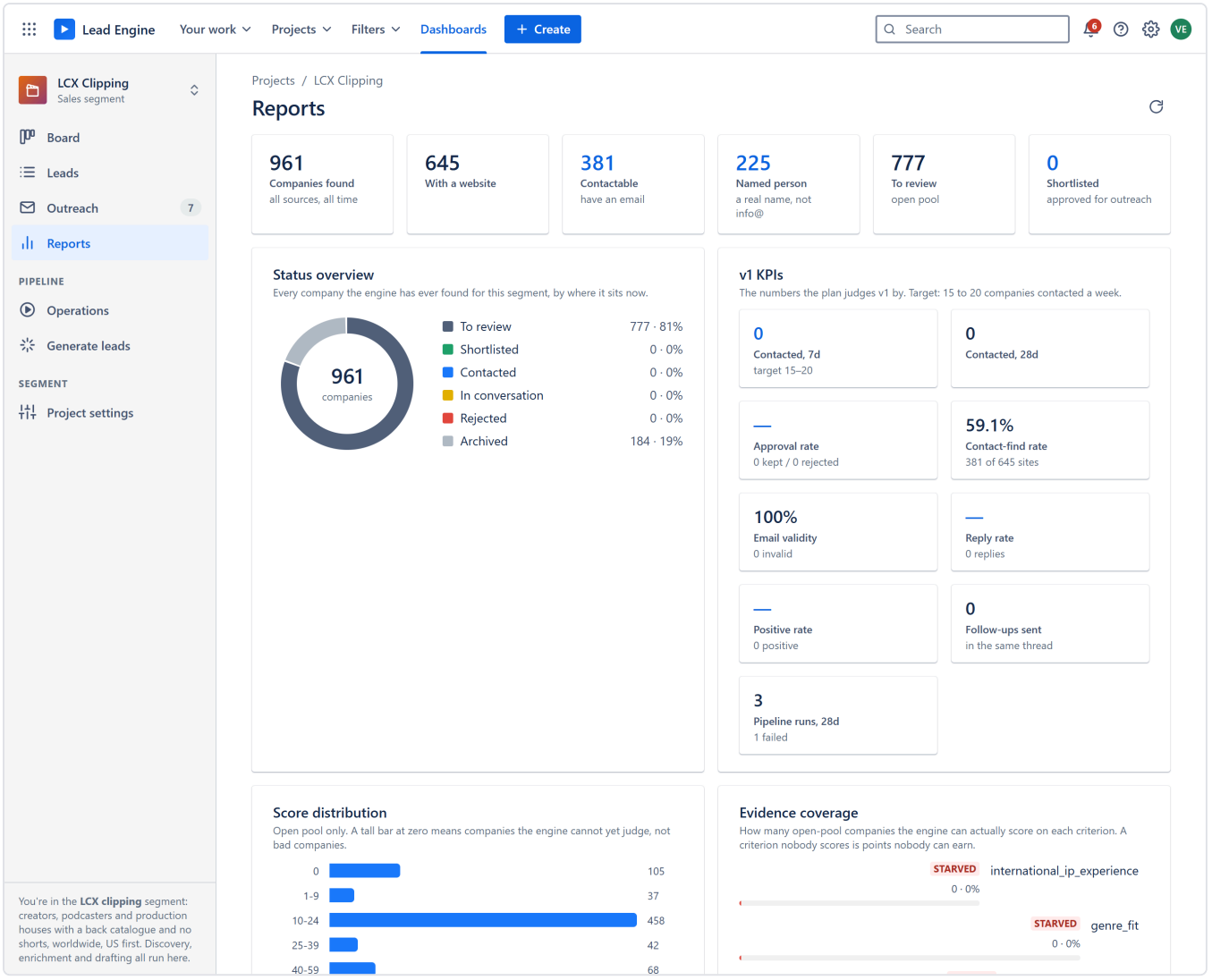
Openers are spread across whichever mailbox has the most room. A follow-up always leaves from the mailbox that sent its opener, because a thread belongs to one mailbox.

Schedule and recent runs

Unattended schedule is what runs without anyone watching, in UTC.

Recent runs is the history: every scheduled or manual run, and the exact step that failed if one did.

Reports



Is this working?

Status overview — every company ever found for this project, and where it sits now.

v1 KPIs — the numbers the plan is judged on. The target is 15 to 20 companies contacted a week.

Score distribution — the open pool by score. A tall bar at zero is not a pile of bad companies; it is companies the engine could not judge yet.

Evidence coverage — how many companies can actually be scored on each criterion. A criterion nobody can be scored on is points nobody can earn, and that is a signal to fix the enrichment, not the rubric.

By source — which connectors are earning their place.

The rules that never bend

These are built into the database, not just into the screens. They hold even if the app has a bug.

No email is ever sent that a person has not read. Approval means a human read that exact text. There is no automatic send, no scheduled send, no "approve all without looking".

One thread per company, ever. An opener and at most two follow-ups. Checked across every project, not just the one you are in, and it survives resets and re-imports.

A rejected lead never comes back. No later harvest will re-import something you turned down.

"Remove me" is permanent. An opt-out request marks that domain unsubscribed forever.

Nothing is claimed that the evidence does not support. Every sentence in an email is built from that lead's own recorded numbers. A lead that already publishes shorts gets no "you publish no shorts" line, because it would not be true of them.

Only public first-party pages are read, and robots.txt is honoured. No LinkedIn scraping. No CAPTCHA bypass. No buying scraped lists.

What only you can do

The engine cannot finish these. Each one needs a person with an account or a card.

1. Fill in the footer. Your name and postal address, in the Footer dialog on the Outreach screen. Until this is done, no email can be approved: the check refuses a draft that still says `SET_ME`.

2. Connect a mailbox. A Gmail OAuth client in Google Cloud, then the address in `.env`, then one browser consent per mailbox:

```
SEGMENT_SLUG=lcx-clipping python tools/outreach.py auth --mailbox main
```

Use addresses on a sending domain that belongs to LCX alone, not the main company domain, so a bad week never touches everyday mail.

3. Shortlist some leads. The engine drafts emails for shortlisted leads. Nothing is shortlisted until you do it.

Optional, and worth having later: an Anthropic key for reply triage, and an alert webhook so a failed overnight run reaches you.

If something looks wrong

"I approved it but nothing was sent." Approving does not send. Someone runs the send command. Check the Approved folder; that is where approved emails wait.

"The screen is blank / says it cannot reach the database." The free cloud instance goes to sleep when it is idle and takes a few seconds to wake. Reload once. If it persists, check Operations for a failed run.

"A lead has no contact." The engine only uses addresses that companies have published themselves. If nobody published one, the lead sits there without one. The enrichment passes add addresses as they find them.

"The greeting says 'Hi there'." That means the engine could not establish a real person's name with confidence, and it will not guess. "Hi there" is correct behaviour; "Hi Tech Talk" would not be.

"A draft will not approve." The dialog names the reason: an unfilled placeholder, a sender that still says `SET_ME`, an address that failed verification, or a company whose status has moved on since the draft was written.

"I rejected something by mistake." Leads list, status filter to Rejected, open it, and change the status with the dropdown at the top right of the dialog.

Words used here

Project (segment) — one sales motion with its own leads, rubric, templates and mailboxes. Switch with the project name at the top of the sidebar.

Lead — one company, show or creator. Has a key like `LCX-CCAB`.

Fit score — out of 110, from the rubric in Project settings. Every point is explained in the lead dialog.

Gate — a hard disqualifier. Fires only on confirmed evidence, never on something the engine failed to check.

Evidence — a fact the engine actually observed, with a record of where it came from.

Draft — an email that has been written and not sent. Inert until approved.

Opener — the first email to a company. **Follow-up** — a later one in the same thread.

Spot check — the random sample the server makes you read before approving a batch.

Warm-up — the ramp on a new mailbox, from ten a day up to forty.

Enrichment — the passes that fill in contacts and evidence on leads already found.